490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 10 OF 26

The Tabernacle: God Moves In

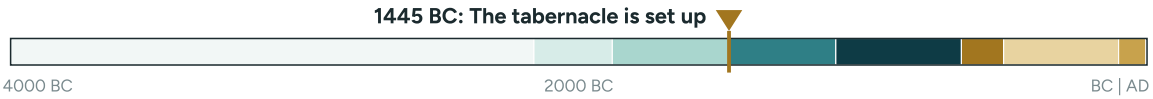
Exodus 25–31; 35–40



David S. Jones

October 17, 2026

YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 10



Introduction: God Moves In

If you read Exodus straight through, something strange happens after the Ten Commandments. The story slows to a crawl. For chapter after chapter you read measurements, fabrics, colors, metals, and furniture: acacia wood overlaid with gold, curtains of blue and purple and scarlet yarn, rings, poles, hooks, and clasps. God gives the instructions in chapters 25–31, and then the book describes the building of every piece all over again in chapters 35–40. Thirteen chapters about a tent. Many new readers quietly skip ahead.

Do not skip it. Those chapters are telling you something stunning, and the size of the section is part of the message. The God who thundered on Sinai, whose holiness made the mountain smoke, is about to move into the middle of a camp of former slaves. The Bible does not linger this long over creation or the flood. It lingers here because this is a giant step toward what the whole story has been heading for since Eden: God living with his people again.

On our timeline, this is about 1445 BC. Israel is still camped at the foot of Sinai, about a year after leaving Egypt. And at the end of Exodus, the cloud of God's glory comes down and fills the tent. This lesson walks you through that tent, piece by piece, from the gate to the inner room, and shows you how every piece points to Jesus.

The Word: Dwelling Place

> **Exodus 25:8–9** *"And let them make me a sanctuary, that I may dwell in their midst. Exactly as I show you concerning the pattern of the tabernacle, and of all its furniture, so you shall make it."*

מִשְׁכָּן *(mishkan, "tabernacle, dwelling place")*

literally "the place where someone dwells"

שָׁכַן (shakan)

"to dwell, to settle"

To live somewhere, often in a tent. "That I may *dwell* in their midst" (25:8).

→

מִשְׁכָּן (mishkan)

"dwelling place"

The word English Bibles translate "tabernacle," an old word for a tent.

Payoff: The tabernacle was not mainly a place for people to go to church. It was God's house, the place where he lived among them. And the idea carries all the way into the New Testament. When John writes, "the Word became flesh and dwelt among us" (John 1:14), the Greek verb means "pitched his tent." Jesus is God's tabernacle in a human body. And on the last page of the Bible: "Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man" (Rev. 21:3). The same picture, from a tent in the desert to a city where God lives with his people forever.

Part One: A Pattern from the Mountain

God did not leave the design to Israel's imagination. "Exactly as I show you concerning the pattern of the tabernacle… so you shall make it" (25:9). And again, "see that you make them after the pattern for them, which is being shown you on the mountain" (25:40). The book of Hebrews explains why the details mattered so much: the tabernacle was "a copy and shadow of the heavenly things" (Heb. 8:5). The tent on earth was a model of a greater reality, the true dwelling place of God.

Two details in these chapters are worth noticing. First, God paid for his house through willing gifts: "From every man whose heart moves him you shall receive the contribution for me" (25:2). The people gave so generously that the craftsmen had to come to Moses and say, "The people bring much more than enough," and Moses had to tell everyone to stop giving (36:5–7). That is what grace does to slaves who have just been set free.

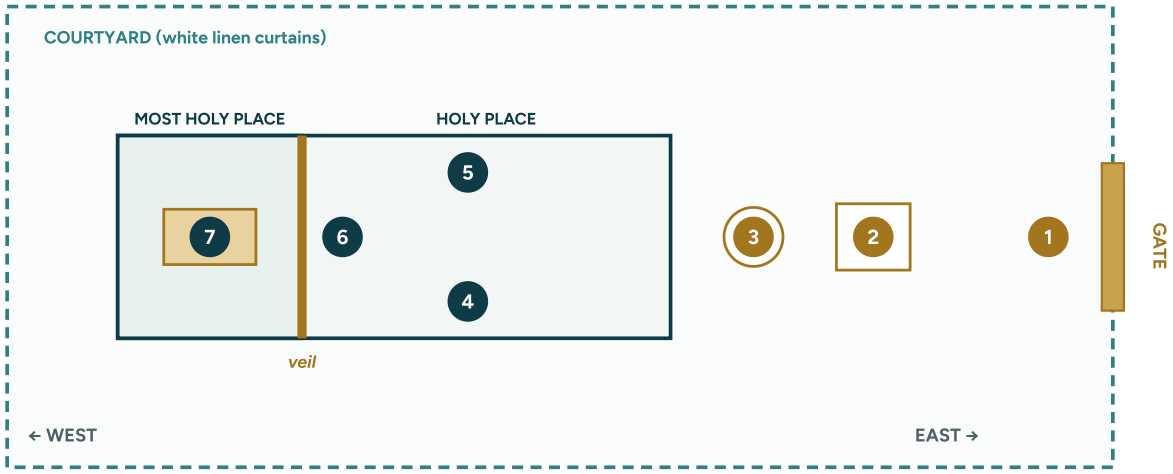
Second, God chose a craftsman named Bezalel and said, "I have filled him with the Spirit of God, with ability and intelligence, with knowledge and all craftsmanship, to devise artistic designs, to work in gold, silver, and bronze" (31:3–4). Bezalel is the first person God himself says he has filled with his Spirit, and he was an artist. Beauty and skill in the service of God are gifts of the Spirit.

Part Two: A Walk Through the Tent

Imagine you are an Israelite walking toward the tabernacle. It sits in the very center of the camp, with the twelve tribes encamped around it on every side. Here is what you would find.

The Tabernacle from Above (Exodus 25–27)

Simplified, not to scale. The courtyard was about 150 by 75 feet.



1. The one gate (east)
2. Bronze altar of sacrifice
3. Bronze basin for washing
4. Golden lampstand (south side)
5. Table with the bread of the Presence
6. Golden altar of incense
7. Ark of the covenant and mercy seat

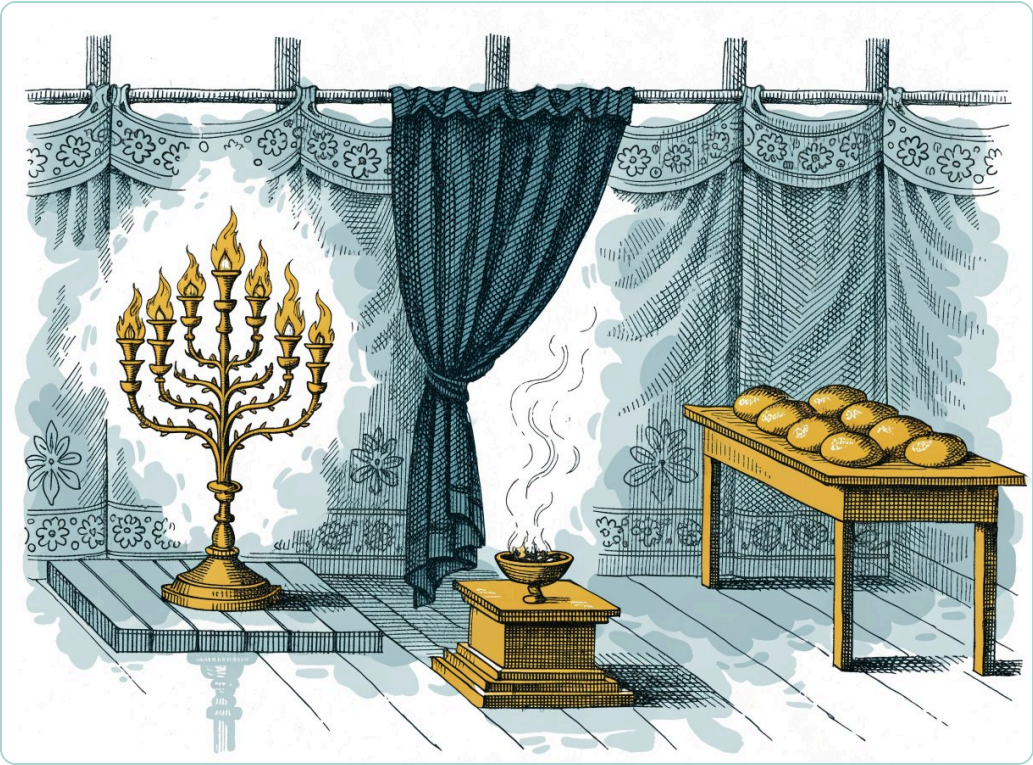
Every step inward is a step closer to God, and the first step is past the altar.

The courtyard and the one gate. A fence of white linen curtains surrounds a courtyard. There is only one way in, a single gate on the east side. You cannot come to God by any entrance you choose.

The bronze altar. The first thing you meet inside the gate is a large altar of wood covered in bronze, with a horn on each corner (27:1–2). This is where the animals were sacrificed. Before anyone could go one step closer to God, something had to die. Next week we will look closely at the sacrifices offered here.

The bronze basin. Between the altar and the tent stood a large bronze basin of water, where the priests washed their hands and feet before serving, "so that they may not die" (30:19–21). Even after the sacrifice, the one who comes near must be made clean.

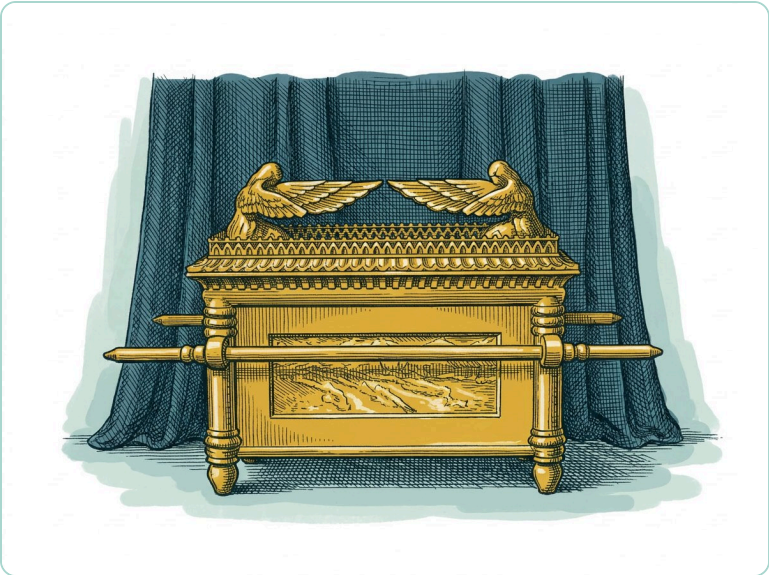
The Holy Place. The tent itself had two rooms. The first, called the Holy Place, held three pieces of gold furniture. On one side, a **golden lampstand** with a central stem, six branches, and seven lamps, its cups shaped like almond blossoms so it looked like a flowering tree (25:31–40). It was the only light in the room. On the other side, a **table** with twelve loaves of bread (Lev. 24:5–9), called "the bread of the Presence," set out "before me regularly" (25:30), one loaf for each tribe, as if Israel were always eating at God's table. And in front of the inner curtain, a small **golden altar of incense**, where sweet-smelling incense burned every morning and evening (30:1–8).



The Holy Place: the lampstand, the table with the bread of the Presence, and the altar of incense before the veil.

The veil. Between the Holy Place and the inner room hung a heavy curtain, a veil "of blue and purple and scarlet yarns and fine twined linen… with cherubim skillfully worked into it" (26:31). Remember the cherubim from Lesson 4, guarding the way back to Eden? Here they are again, woven into the curtain. The way into God's presence was still guarded.

The Most Holy Place. Behind the veil was a small square room with one piece of furniture: **the ark of the covenant**, a wooden chest covered in gold. Inside it were the stone tablets of the Ten Commandments (25:16). On top of it was a lid of pure gold called the **mercy seat**, with two golden cherubim facing each other, their wings stretched over it (25:17–20). And God said, "There I will meet with you, and from above the mercy seat, from between the two cherubim that are on the ark of the testimony, I will speak with you about all that I will give you in commandment for the people of Israel" (25:22).



"There I will meet with you, and from above the mercy seat, from between the two cherubim… I will speak with you" (Ex. 25:22).

Think about the picture. Inside the ark was the law Israel would break, the law that on its own could only condemn them. Over the law was the mercy seat. And over the mercy seat was the presence of God. The place where God met his people was a lid of mercy covering the law they could not keep. Once a year the high priest would sprinkle blood on that very lid. That is next week's lesson.

CORE DOCTRINE 10 OF 26

The Holiness of God

God is holy. He is utterly pure and set apart from everything sinful and ordinary, and his glory is beyond us. That is why the tabernacle had a curtain and why sinners could not simply walk into his presence. Only a sacrifice and a priest could open the way.

KEY VERSES

Exodus 15:11; Leviticus 19:2; Isaiah 6:1–5; Hebrews 12:28–29

WHAT THE CHURCH CONFESSES

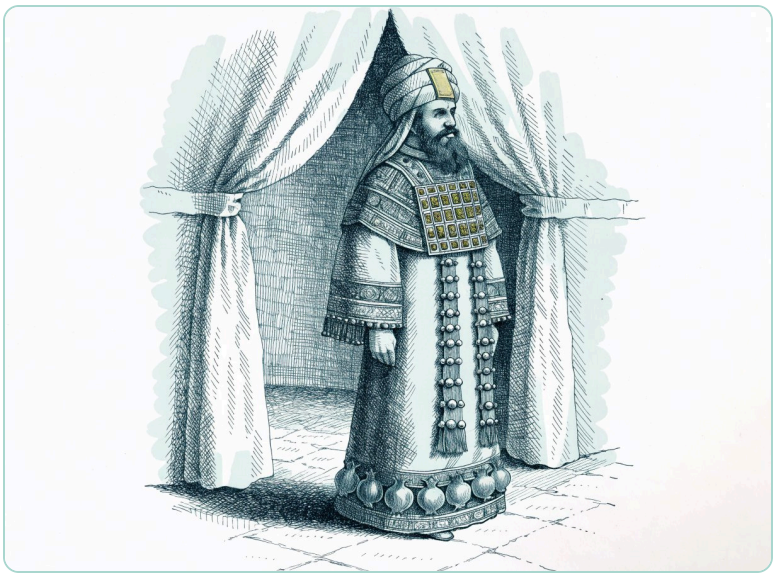
"He is most holy in all his counsels, in all his works, and in all his commands." (Westminster Confession of Faith 2.2)

WHY IT MATTERS

Only when we see how holy God is do we see how amazing it is that he welcomes sinners through Christ.

Part Three: The Priests

Sinful people living around a holy God needed a mediator, a go-between (remember that word from Lesson 5). God appointed Moses' brother Aaron as high priest, and Aaron's sons as priests (28:1). God told Moses to make them "holy garments… for glory and for beauty" (28:2).



"So Aaron shall bear the names of the sons of Israel in the breastpiece of judgment on his heart, when he goes into the Holy Place" (Ex. 28:29).

Two details of the high priest's clothing show you what his job was. On his chest he wore a breastpiece set with twelve precious stones, each engraved with the name of one of the tribes of Israel. "So Aaron shall bear the names of the sons of Israel in the breastpiece of judgment on his heart, when he goes into the Holy Place, to bring them to regular remembrance before the LORD" (28:29). Every time the high priest went in before God, he carried the people on his heart. And on his turban was a gold plate engraved with the words, "Holy to the LORD" (28:36), so that the people "may be accepted before the LORD" (28:38). Aaron was a sinner himself, so the plate was a promise more than a description. The people were accepted because their priest carried their guilt before God (28:38). One day a Priest would come who is holy all the way through (Heb. 7:26).

Part Four: The Glory Fills the Tent

Before the tabernacle was ever built, there was a crisis. After the golden calf, God told Moses he would still give Israel the land, "but I will not go up among you, lest I consume you on the way, for you are a stiff-necked people" (33:3). Moses interceded, and God promised: "My presence will go with you, and I will give you rest" (33:14). Moses held him to that promise: "If your presence will not go with me, do not bring us up from here" (33:15). He understood that the land without God was not worth having, and he knew the one thing that set Israel apart: "Is it not in your going with us, so that we are distinct, I and your people, from every other people on the face of the earth?" (33:16). And God answered, "This very thing that you have spoken I will do" (33:17).

So they built it. "In the first month in the second year, on the first day of the month, the tabernacle was erected" (40:17). Moses set up every piece exactly as God had shown him. And then:

> **Exodus 40:34–35** *"Then the cloud covered the tent of meeting, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle. And Moses was not able to enter the tent of meeting because the cloud settled on it, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle."*

The God of the burning bush, the God of the pillar of fire, the God of the smoking mountain had come to live in a tent among his people. From then on, whenever the cloud lifted, Israel packed up and followed it; when it stayed, they stayed. "For the cloud of the LORD was on the tabernacle by day, and fire was in it by night, in the sight of all the house of Israel throughout all their journeys" (40:38). That is how Exodus ends. A book that began with God's people as slaves in Egypt ends with God himself living in the middle of their camp.

Every Piece Points to Jesus

IN THE TABERNACLE		FULFILLED IN CHRIST
The one gate *Only one way in*	→	"I am the door" (John 10:9)
Bronze altar *Blood before entry*	→	"A single sacrifice for sins" (Heb. 10:12)
Bronze basin *Washing to serve*	→	Washed clean by Christ (Titus 3:5; Heb. 10:22)
Lampstand *The only light inside*	→	"I am the light of the world" (John 8:12)
Bread of the Presence *Israel at God's table*	→	"I am the bread of life" (John 6:35)
Altar of incense *Prayer rising to God*	→	He always lives to intercede (Heb. 7:25)
The veil *The way still barred*	→	Torn at his death; his flesh (Matt. 27:51; Heb. 10:20)
Ark and mercy seat *Mercy over the law*	→	Christ our propitiation (Rom. 3:25)

"A copy and shadow of the heavenly things" (Heb. 8:5).

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE The tabernacle is a garden in a tent. Its entrance faced east, like Eden's (Gen. 3:24). Cherubim guarded the inner room, as they guarded the garden. The lampstand was decorated like a blossoming tree. Gold covered its furniture, and onyx stones sat on the high priest's shoulders (Ex. 28:9), the same treasures Genesis names in the land beside Eden (Gen. 2:11–12). God was rebuilding, in miniature, the home humanity had lost.

THE LAMB The first thing inside the gate was the altar. There was no way to the mercy seat except past the place of sacrifice. Every Israelite who walked toward God's dwelling walked past blood first. Next week we stand at that altar, and then follow the high priest behind the veil on the Day of Atonement.

The Turn: The Word Pitched His Tent

Nearly fifteen hundred years later, the glory came to live among God's people again. John writes, "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only Son from the Father, full of grace and truth" (John 1:14). The eternal Son of God "tabernacled" among us. In Jesus, the glory that filled the tent walked the roads of Galilee, ate with sinners, and touched lepers. When Jesus said, "Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up," John explains, "he was speaking about the temple of his body" (John 2:19, 21).

Walk back through the tent with Jesus in mind. He is the one gate: "I am the door" (John 10:9). He is the sacrifice on the altar. He is the light of the world (John 8:12) and the bread of life (John 6:35). He is our great high priest who carries our names before God and "always lives to make intercession" for us (Heb. 7:25). And when he died, the curtain in the temple, the successor to this very veil, "was torn in two, from top to bottom" (Matt. 27:51). Now "we have confidence to enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus, by the new and living way that he opened for us through the curtain, that is, through his flesh" (Heb. 10:19–20). Paul even uses the word for the mercy seat when he says God put Christ forward "as a propitiation by his blood" (Rom. 3:25), the place where God's anger at sin is turned away and mercy meets us.

And it goes further. Through his Spirit, God now lives in his people: "Do you not know that you are God's temple and that God's Spirit dwells in you?" (1 Cor. 3:16). You are being "built together into a dwelling place for God by the Spirit" (Eph. 2:22). At the end, there will be no temple at all, "for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb" (Rev. 21:22).

Moses could not enter the tent when the glory filled it. Because of Jesus, you are invited in. "Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace, that we may receive mercy and find grace to help in time of need" (Heb. 4:16). Turn from your sin, trust the High Priest who opened the way, and come.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Walk the tent.** Read Exodus 25:1–22 and 40:16–38. Then trace the floor plan diagram from the gate to the ark, and name how each piece points to Christ.

2. **Give freely.** Israel gave more than enough. Give something this week with a willing heart, simply because God has been generous to you.

3. **Use your gifts.** Bezalel's art was a gift of the Spirit. What skill do you have that you could offer for God's glory?

4. **Pray Moses' prayer.** "If your presence will not go with me, do not bring us up from here." Ask God to go with you into one hard thing this week.

5. **Draw near.** Spend ten minutes in prayer with Hebrews 4:16 open before you. Come with confidence because of your High Priest.

6. **Memorize John 1:14.** "And the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory."

Before Lesson 11: *Read Leviticus 1, 16, and Hebrews 9:11–10:18. Lesson 11 stands at the altar and follows the high priest behind the veil.*

For Discussion

1. Exodus spends thirteen chapters on the tabernacle. Why do you think God cared so much about the details of his dwelling place?
2. The people gave so much that Moses told them to stop. What makes a person give like that?
3. Walk through the tabernacle from the gate to the ark. What does the order of the furniture teach about coming to God?
4. Inside the ark was the law; over it was the mercy seat. What does that picture say to you?
5. The high priest carried Israel's names on his heart. Jesus carries the names of everyone who comes to God through him (Heb. 7:25). What would it mean for you to know he carries yours?
6. Moses would rather stay in the desert than enter the Promised Land without God (Ex. 33:15). What would you be tempted to settle for without God?
7. Christians together are now God's temple (1 Cor. 3:16), and each believer's body is a temple of the Spirit (1 Cor. 6:19). How should that change the way you treat your church, other believers, and your own body?

Sources & For Further Study

- On מִשְׁכָּן and שָׁכַן: Brown, Driver, and Briggs, *Hebrew and English Lexicon*; Koehler and Baumgartner, *HALOT*, s.v. On σκηνόω in John 1:14: Bauer, Danker, Arndt, and Gingrich (BDAG), s.v.
- On Eden and the tabernacle: Gordon J. Wenham, "Sanctuary Symbolism in the Garden of Eden Story" (1986); G. K. Beale, *The Temple and the Church's Mission*.
- For further reading: Philip Graham Ryken, *Exodus: Saved for God's Glory* (Preaching the Word); Vern S. Poythress, *The Shadow of Christ in the Law of Moses*; L. Michael Morales, *Who Shall Ascend the Mountain of the Lord?*



David S. Jones

Author of *Seventy Times Seven: On the God Who Forgives Past All Counting*. He teaches Scripture every week or so at 490.life, serves on the worship teams at Scottsdale Bible Church, and serves in the men's group, The Forge, helping to disciple men and pointing them to Jesus. He coaches and mentors men one-to-one and speaks to churches and men's groups.

© 2026 490 Life Publishing · David S. Jones · Scripture quotations from the ESV · 490.life